

PDA Phones

PDA phones converge two widely used mobile devices—the cell phone and the Personal Digital Assistant (PDA). Initially, the functionality of these two devices were combined to form a single unit. However, as time progressed, advanced technologies were integrated to make it a device with almost the potential to replace a laptop. As of now, most integrate Bluetooth and Wi-Fi as well.

Large and better-quality colour screens have made their way to these products. Most PDA phones sport at least a 65K colour screen. Newer generation phones promise better screens capable of playing video in full-blown colour.

The Symbian OS has been the base on which most PDA phones run, but Microsoft and

Palm are developing their own OSes for the mobile market. While the MS PocketPC and Palm OS are quite good at PDA functionality, they are not up to it when it comes to the integration of cell phone features.

However, this is temporary; changes are in the pipeline. Nokia has, for long, avoided the concept of PDA phones; however, that will change in a few months with the introduction of their first true PDA phone.

The amount of memory that these phones incorporate has gone from a paltry 4 MB to 90 MB in just two years. However, manufacturers have realised that Flash-based memories are not the answer, and it is high time to look out for hard disks as the best possible alternative for high capacity storage.

Bluetooth has matured for

Ready Reckoner	
 You Need	A decent PDA phone that does not cost a bomb and has all the necessary features
Look for	Models such as Motorola A760 offer necessary features and cost no more than Rs 20,000
 You Need	A full featured PDA phone with all possible features of both world-cell phone and PDAs
Look for	PDA phone such as Sony-Ericsson P910 is your best option. This phone has a digital camera, MP3 player, video-capture, scheduler, etc



short-range wireless communication; however, it is Wi-Fi in PDA phones that will open the floodgates. Not only will you be able to talk using a cell phone service, you will also be able to use VoIP services such as Skype.

On the multimedia front, things are already in place; almost all PDA phones today have support for MP3 audio, and can play video files. PDA phones will take integrated cameras to the next level of clarity and finesse. As time progresses, things will get rosier, and streaming on your PDA phone is not a distant possibility.

Elements Of A PDA Phone

Display: A large colour touch-sensitive screen capable of displaying 65K colours or more. The screen is also used for data input via a stylus.

Memory Slot: A memory slot lets you plug more memory into the phone. More storage will become a necessity once the mail in your Inbox, and your MP3 collection, outgrows the onboard memory.

Stylus: A stylus with a good grip will make handwriting recognition work better.

Buying Tips

- ✓ Globetrotters should look out for GSM PDA phones that operate on almost all GSM networks (800/1800/1900) across the world, often called tri-band.
- ✓ Check out the battery life before you decide to buy. Features such as bigger and brighter screens, Bluetooth, and Wi-Fi will drain more power and will reduce the effective talk and standby time.
- ✓ Bluetooth headsets are quite handy when driving or travelling since they let you attend a call without touching the phone.
- ✓ Look out for the functionalities that the phone offers. Play around with the interface; input some data; that should give you a clear idea of your comfort level with the phone.
- ✓ Before buying, check the synch features provided by the phone; look out for synching

with common applications such as Microsoft Outlook, Address Book, etc.

- ✓ Instead of buying expensive cables for synching, rely on Bluetooth adapters as they are compact and easy to carry around. Also, they can be connected to any machine without much fuss.
- ✓ With support for technologies such as GPRS, EDGE, etc, a proper smartphone can completely replace a laptop for checking e-mail and for Web browsing.
- ✓ Choose a PDA phone that suites your needs and lifestyle, and one that reflects your attitude.
- ✓ People with heavy usage patterns should invest in a high-capacity battery, or at least buy extra battery packs. Along with a battery pack, invest in a good compact travel charger.